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February 2, 2026

To Whom It May Concern:

I am writing to recommend Gabby Sigal for the Academic Senate Distinguished Teaching Award for TAs. I have worked with many TAs over the years, and Gabby is one of the best I have ever worked with.

I had the pleasure of getting to know Gabby as a Teaching Assistant for Human Systems Anatomy (Physiological Sciences 107) (she had previously taken the course as an undergraduate and done well and had also been a Learning Assistant for the course). This is the first course taken by PhySci majors and is meant to introduce them to the 'human machine', as well as to the rigors of the major. This is a large course, often with 250+ students, 5-6 Teaching Assistants (TAs) and 15-20 undergraduate Learning Assistants (LAs), making it a logistical nightmare. In this distinct environment, Gabby exceled as a valuable member of the team. She was a TA for one year, before becoming the lead TA for the course the following year and did a phenomenal job in the position. I co-teach this course, and my co-instructor and I often relied on Gabby to take care of the things we often neglected. Gabby was always on top of rescheduling students who couldn't attend lab because of illness, as well as during holiday and testing weeks. She was our main contact with the LAs during our weekly meetings, making sure they knew what was expected of them, and she also kept up on the various supplies we need for the course.

Gabby did all this while being an excellent teacher. Her students enjoyed her enthusiasm and she always received excellent reviews. Throughout it all, she was a pleasant colleague to work with, who always brought a positive energy to our meetings, and the class in general.

Gabby will excel in all she does, and she is an excellent candidate for this award. Please contact me if any further information is needed.

Sincerely,

Anthony Friscia

Anthony Friscia, Ph.D.
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Majoring in Physiological Sciences (Physci) at UCLA and taking the core series classes as a student deepened my passion for physiology and pursuing medicine as a long-term career goal. Thus, when given the opportunity to serve as a teaching assistant (TA) for these same courses that once inspired me, I jumped at the opportunity, hoping to inspire other students in the same way that I once was and serve as a resource for them - academically and personally, supporting them on their journey towards success. Through this support, I am able to challenge my students to become the best version of themselves, directly aligning with the values supported by the Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award.

To serve these students academically, I go beyond the standard expectations for my role. The material discussed in Physci develops quickly, making it difficult for students to balance the workload on top of their other classes. Knowing this, I decided to create handwritten "fill-in-the-blank-worksheets" for each week's concepts. These worksheets consist of drawings, tables, graphs, and other forms of content delivery that I fill out with the students together in our weekly discussion sections while clarifying any misconceptions about the material. As time progressed, I noticed a shift in my students, not only in terms of their performance, but in their morale. My students came to discussion sections eager to learn, knowing they would have a stronger understanding of the material and be more confident in their abilities to understand challenging information. While teaching and clarifying concepts is inherently part of my role, the most rewarding aspect is observing my students grow as learners with my help.

Another intense aspect of the curriculum is the ability to analyze research papers, a task which is difficult for students with limited experience. Knowing how daunting it is to read research papers, I hosted a workshop for all 250 students, discussing how to read a research paper. I explained the various parts of a research paper as well as analyzed an example paper in real-time with them, vocalizing my thought-process. I provided a general outline that I recommended for them to use: for each experiment, I would explain the purpose, methods, and result in one sentence, showing the level of detail that is expected of them. Following the workshop, various students would come to my office hours with these outlines for each paper, and I saw the students excel both in their abilities to critically analyze a paper as well as the general expansion of their scientific knowledge. By keeping active and student-centered learning central to my teaching approach, I aim to embody a consistent commitment to effective learning.

Now as a second year Master's student teaching the Physci core series once, I have been promoted to serve as the head teaching assistant. In addition to teaching discussion sections, I serve as a liaison between the students, professors, learning assistants, and other teaching assistants, ensuring everyone is informed about deadlines, examinations, and other logistical aspects of the course. Furthermore, I serve as a mentor to other first year TAs, both part of the Physci teaching team and the MCIP department, allowing them to shadow my discussion sections to obtain insight into my teaching style, as well as serve as a point of reference for any questions they have. I am always open to receiving questions, and in doing so, my peers and my students have developed a sense of trust in me, knowing that I will be there to guide them no matter what the situation may be. I intentionally aim to build a community within the Physci

teaching team based on inclusivity, excellence, and an unwavering commitment to support one another's growth as educators while prioritizing student success, reflecting the core values celebrated by the Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award.

Ultimately, serving as a TA has been an extremely rewarding experience. I have challenged myself in my ability to teach and clarify complex material, while simultaneously guiding and serving my fellow teaching team and students through their journeys. Through my independently developed instructional materials, targeted academic support, and expanded leadership serving as head TA, I have sought to positively impact students and fellow instructors by helping them navigate the challenges that come with difficult courses, directly aligning with the values recognized by the Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award.

As a student embarking on the journey that constitutes being a Physiological Sciences Major, I remember how overwhelming the major felt at times. The material I was learning had been the most complex and dense information in all of my undergraduate education, and there were instances where I felt like I did not belong in the major, or in the healthcare field in general, because of my struggles. It was not until my own TA for the core series reassured me of my abilities, both inside and outside of the classroom, to tackle and embrace academic challenges. Now, as a TA for this same course, I attempt to emulate my previous TAs teaching practices through my own to inspire students and empower the next generation of scholars. My teaching philosophy is grounded in three core pillars in order to foster a supportive learning environment: mentorship both inside and outside of the classroom, embracing diversity, and encouraging inquisitive and active learning.

When serving as a TA, students often come to me to ask both academic and personal questions, especially as many of them are pre-health and may be pursuing a graduate education. Knowing that I'm a Master's student, they often seek guidance about why I decided to do the Master's program, my research interests, and my pre-medical journey overall, in order to get insight for their future and their next steps after college. Having been in their same shoes, I not only welcome questions that may be out of the scope of the class content, but I encourage them, as I want to serve as a mentor to these students and guide them on their journeys. I do my best to create a space filled with transparency and honesty by sharing my own educational and personal hardships that I've had to overcome. This allows me to normalize the challenges that often accompany pursuing higher education, especially for individuals who are first generation college students and do not have other resources they can rely on or are the first members of their family pursuing a career in healthcare. By telling students my story, I hope to resonate with them and instill confidence, reinforcing that they can accomplish anything that they put their minds to. Serving as a mentor, both academically and personally, for all of my students is a great privilege that continues to be a central guiding principle behind my teaching philosophy.

In addition to serving as a mentor, another key component of my teaching philosophy is the importance of embracing diversity, particularly in fostering collaboration. Coming from an immigrant background myself, I have firsthand experienced the struggles that come with assimilation and how difficult it can be to succeed in the face of adversity. These struggles have taught me to extend empathy and compassion to my own students, especially those from diverse backgrounds. When engaging in academic conversation, I strive to be cognizant of different cultural and educational backgrounds and exhibit patience and understanding for different levels of knowledge. For instance, when leading a lab section for my anatomy course and introducing anatomical language, I am cognizant of the fact that some students may have previous exposure due to family members with healthcare backgrounds, while others may be struggling to grasp the fundamentals of anatomy as they are the first person in their family to obtain a college education. Despite these differences, I continuously encourage students to collaborate with one-another, whether it is through think-pair-share activities, viewing cadaver specimens in groups, or other methods, emphasizing that each student brings valuable perspectives that can enrich their peers'

learning. Diversity of culture goes hand in hand with diversity of thought, experiences, and perspectives, and as a TA, I do my best to bring this mentality into every lesson plan and activity in order to foster equitable and nondiscriminatory environments where all students not only feel welcomed, but valued.

In addition to mentorship and embracing diversity, I strive to instill and support curiosity in the classroom through various manners, primarily through active learning strategies. I handmake “fill-in-the-blank” worksheets that are tailored to course material, and this method of teaching allows for students to not only recall information, but actively synthesize and apply their knowledge, especially to clinical scenarios as many of these students are pre-health. Additionally, I very thoughtfully pose questions that invite student exploration rather than simple recall- instead of explaining concepts myself, I instead ask, “How do you think this process occurs and why do you think it is important?”. This allows for students to question their own understanding of the material as well as question how this information can apply to their everyday lives, promoting learning driven by inquiry and genuine interest rather than solely by exam performance. As a teacher, it is my responsibility to not only clarify content, but also prepare students for their future endeavours, where inquiry is central to advancement in the scientific field. I hope that my efforts in promoting inquiry through active learning strategies will play a pivotal role as my students embark on the rest of their undergraduate education and ultimately their careers.

Ultimately, my teaching philosophy is guided by my desire to serve as a mentor, embrace diversity, and support inquiry in my students and peers. Serving as a second year TA, and currently the head TA, for the Physci core series has only deepened my desire to guide my students through their educational journey, and I hope that my efforts will continue to inspire students to grow, embrace challenges, and be the best version of themselves.

Intro: Nociceptors exposed to capsaicin perceive pain. Prolonged exposure leads to capsaicin insensitivity.

Knowledge Gap: What is capsaicin's mechanism of action?

Figure #1:

- **purpose**: no information on molecular structure of capsaicin receptor
- **method**: used cloning strategy via Ca^{2+} influx into sensory neurons to isolate capsaicin cDNA
- **result**: clone named "VR1" showed capsaicin sensitivity

Figure #2:

- **purpose**: compare pharmacology of VR1 to natural VR sites
- **method**: whole-cell voltage clamp on Xenopus oocytes to see response with applied agonists + antagonists
- **result**: capsaicin exposure produced inward current responses in VR1 expressing-oocytes but not controls

Figure #3:

- **purpose**: characterize electrophysiology of VR1 at whole + single-cell level
- **method**: patch-clamp on VR1 expressing cells
- **result**: capsaicin response involves opening of non-selective cation channel ; prefers Ca^{2+} (divalent) over Na^{+} (monovalent)

Gabby is one of the most knowledgable and reasonable instructors I have ever met. She's phenomenal and knows her stuff down to the core. No comments, I have never felt more at home in my major than when I am in her section.

Gabby is the best TA I have ever had at UCLA. It is extremely clear that she cares for not only our understanding of the course content but also about our wellbeing and success as UCLA students in general. I have never felt shy about asking Gabby a question, whether it be about content we are covering in lab or general worries as a student who is trying to find her way as a pre–med. Because of Gabby, I am now interested in pursuing a masters in Physiology at UCLA, and I am super excited for future major–related courses. She's awesome!

Gabby was excellent, always checking in with all of her students

I appreciate how direct and clear the information was presented

Gabby is an amazing TA! She was always so open to answering any questions that we had about the course and lab content, and she would take time to re–explain concepts both inside and outside her office hours if we were struggling to understand the material. She was a really fair grader, and I think because of the way that she explained and taught us content, I was able to grasp and take a lot more content from this class than if I did not have her as my TA. I'd highly recommend Gabby as a TA and am so glad that I had the opportunity to take the class with her.

Gabby has been the most clear, concise, and considerate TA I have had at UCLA. Gabby is very timely and is extremely helpful in outlining difficult concepts in a difficult, but very rewarding class.

Gabby is an incredible TA and deserves whatever promotion she is possibly up for. I have had her for the last 2 quarters and have seen significant improvement in my writing skills. She was always available for me to talk about our critique writing assignments and I don't think I would made such improvements in my critiques without her help and her challenging me to say more with less words and think about the experiments on a deeper level. In terms of class content, Gabby is very knowledgable about all the subjects. I wish we had discussed in section heart failure and PV loop adjustments a bit more but in Gabby's defense we had a ton of heart stuff to cover in a very limited amount of time. Gabby is a fantastic TA not just because she knows her stuff, but that she is a great communicator, gives you advice for the class, is straightforward and supportive, and most importantly, a great teacher. Her worksheets were immensely helpful this quarter. If you are seeing this Gabby, good luck to you in the future!

Gabby is the reason I am still in this major. She provided me more help than the lectures did. Genuinely would not be here if it wasn't for Gabby's discussion worksheets. Gabby is knowledgeable but also straightforward which is very helpful when asking for feedback. She also genuinely cares about her students and always checks in on us. Gonna miss you Gabby!

Love Gabby. She creates amazing resources for her students to study off of, despite them being time–consuming/potentially inconvenient to make. Always answers questions thoroughly and is always available for extra support. Great teaching style and pace, and great attitude. No weaknesses.

For reference, I only had as a TA for 107 and 111A. I really liked Gabby's format for discussions and I feel like I actually learned something because I was engaged. She is very straightforward for what we should and should not know, and I appreciate that.

Gabby is by far the best TA I have ever had at UCLA. She is extremely welcoming and kind, and is clearly very concerned about our understanding of the material. She is straight to the point and knowledgeable about the material, and has been a great person to look up to.

Ms. Sigal is extremely organized and prepared for each section. She has extremely clear understanding of the material and is able to articulate it very well.

Very approachable and thorough!

She is very knowledgable about the material. Even early in the morning at 8 am, she still has energy and is able to effectively teach us the material. I also appreciate that she makes us critically think about the lecture material instead of just reading off of slides. She is also very willing to explain any and all questions if we don't understand something. She is also very perceptive and knows if we got confused by something she says or mentions. The only weakness I can think of is that she always says to study everything, which is fair, but it would be helpful to be more specific.

Gabby is the best TA ever! She has a mastery over the material, paired with an excellent way to present the material to clarify confusing topics and engage the discussion.

I LOVE GABBY! Biggest fan ever. She's been the best TA for the past three quarters, and I always feel supported when I ask her for anything from course–related questions to general questions about the PhySci major. Her notes single–handedly helped me study a lot of the content throughout this year and especially this quarter. I am very grateful for her kindness and openness to support students throughout office hours and being so quick to answer our questions, typically in the span of a few office hours. Gabby may be the best TA that I have had in my UCLA career so far, and I would highly highly recommend her to anyone that takes the PhySci core classes.

I think that Gabby does a great job keeping us engaged as a discussion section and helping our learning by doing interactive worksheets/slides that allow us to answer the questions ourselves.

Gabby is my favorite TA ever. I've had her all three quarters of the physci core series and she's actually so awesome. No weaknesses

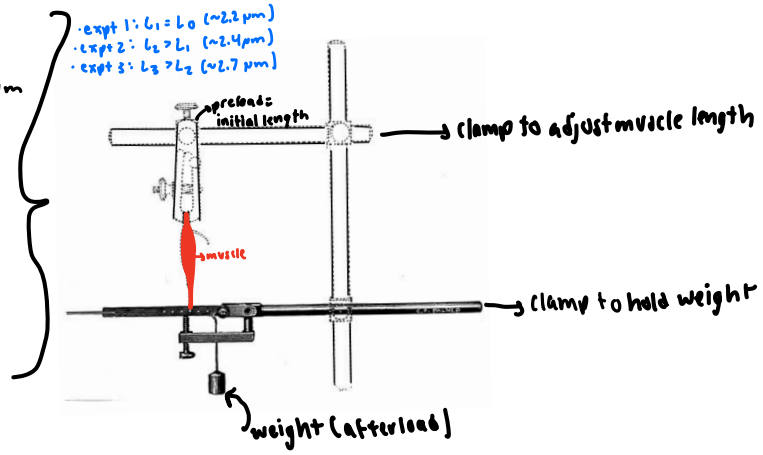
She is really helpful with her worksheet. I really appreciate all the effort she puts in into helping us.

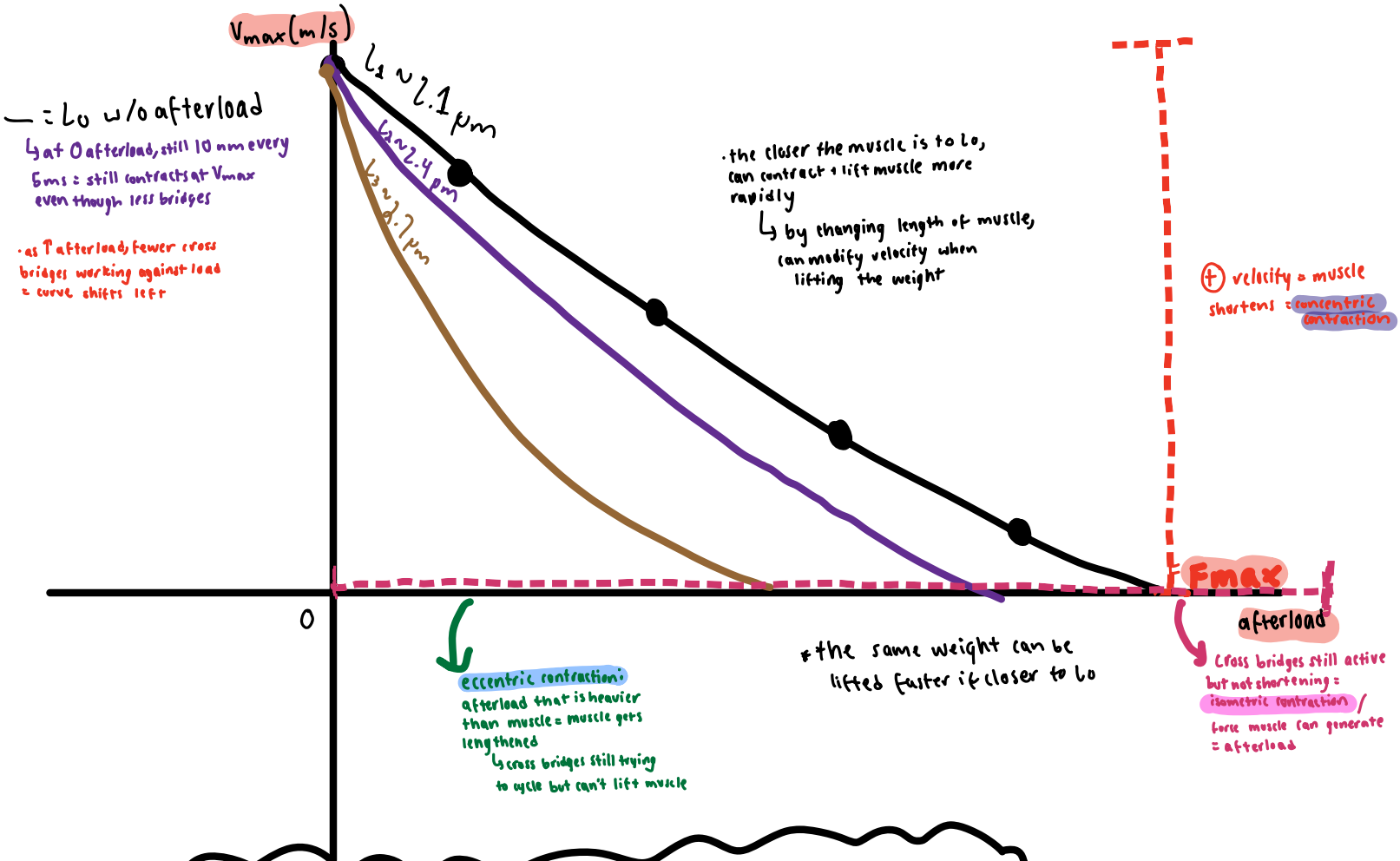
Wonderful TA, format of material presented in good notes is incredibly appreciated. Helpful in content understanding and responsive for questions over email

Length-Velocity Curve:

of a loaded muscle

1. adjust length of muscle via changes in pre-load (relative to L_0)
2. stimulate muscle to contract
3. measure V_i = initial velocity where we chose muscle length
4. increase weight of afterload, repeat steps 2-4



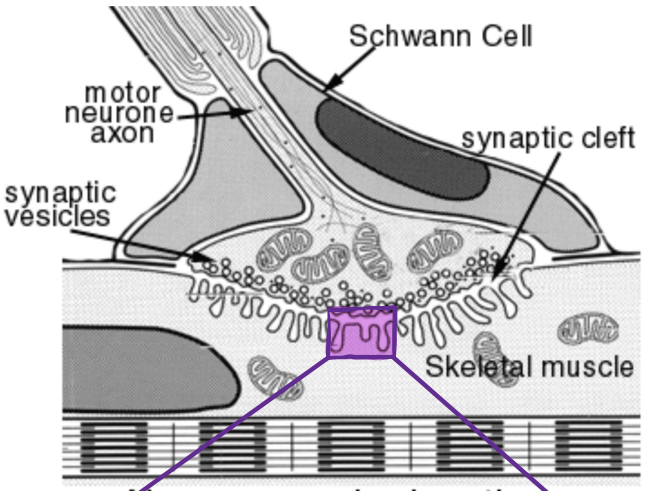


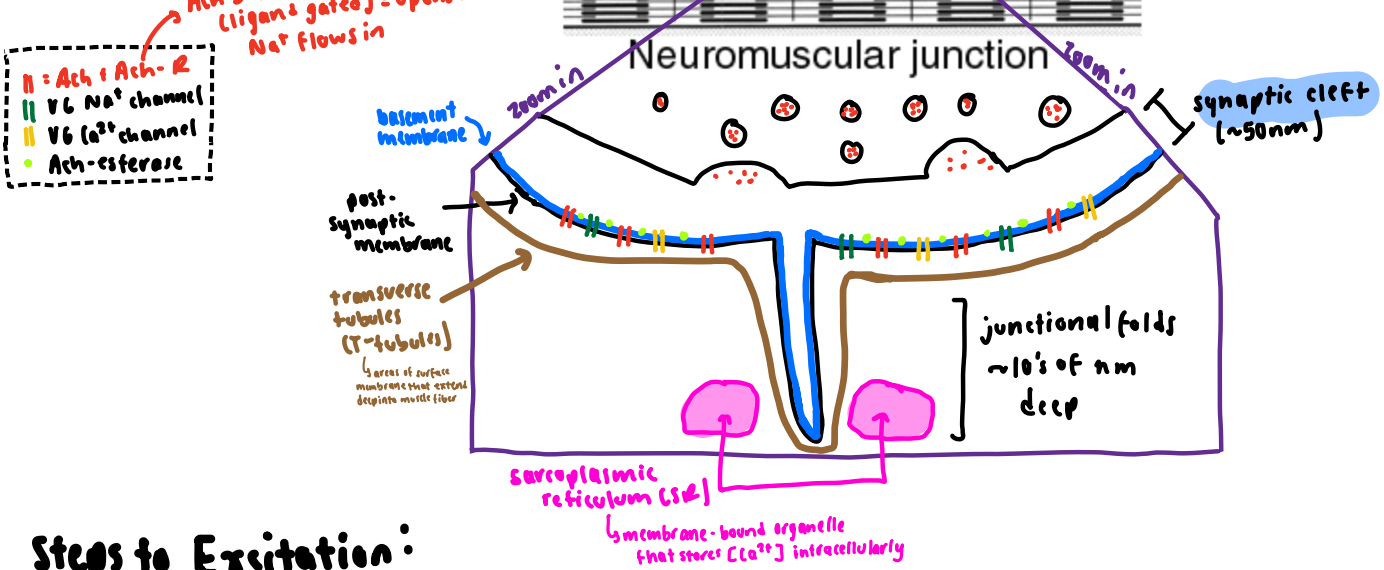
Excitation-Contraction Coupling

AP/EPP in NMJ from somatic motor neuron

↑ in cytosolic [Ca^{2+}] in muscle fiber

- whole process of E → C = 10 ms! (very fast)
- usually have 1 NMJ per 1 muscle fiber





Steps to Excitation:

1. Ach released from SMN, diffuses across synaptic cleft
2. Ach binds to Ach-R
3. Ach-R opens
4. Na^+ influx down [] gradient
5. if enough Na^+ influx, get AP in muscle cell
6. AchE hydrolyzes Ach
7. Ach released off Ach-R
8. Ach-R close

} occurs in 1-2 ms (slowed by diffusion of Ach across cleft

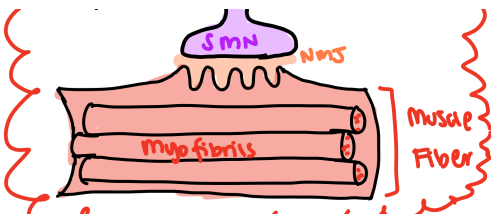
V6 Na^+ channel:

- located throughout surface + post-synaptic membrane
- propagates rapid depolarization to muscle fiber that only occurs in one small region

* NMJ = only 0.01% of entire surface area of muscle membrane

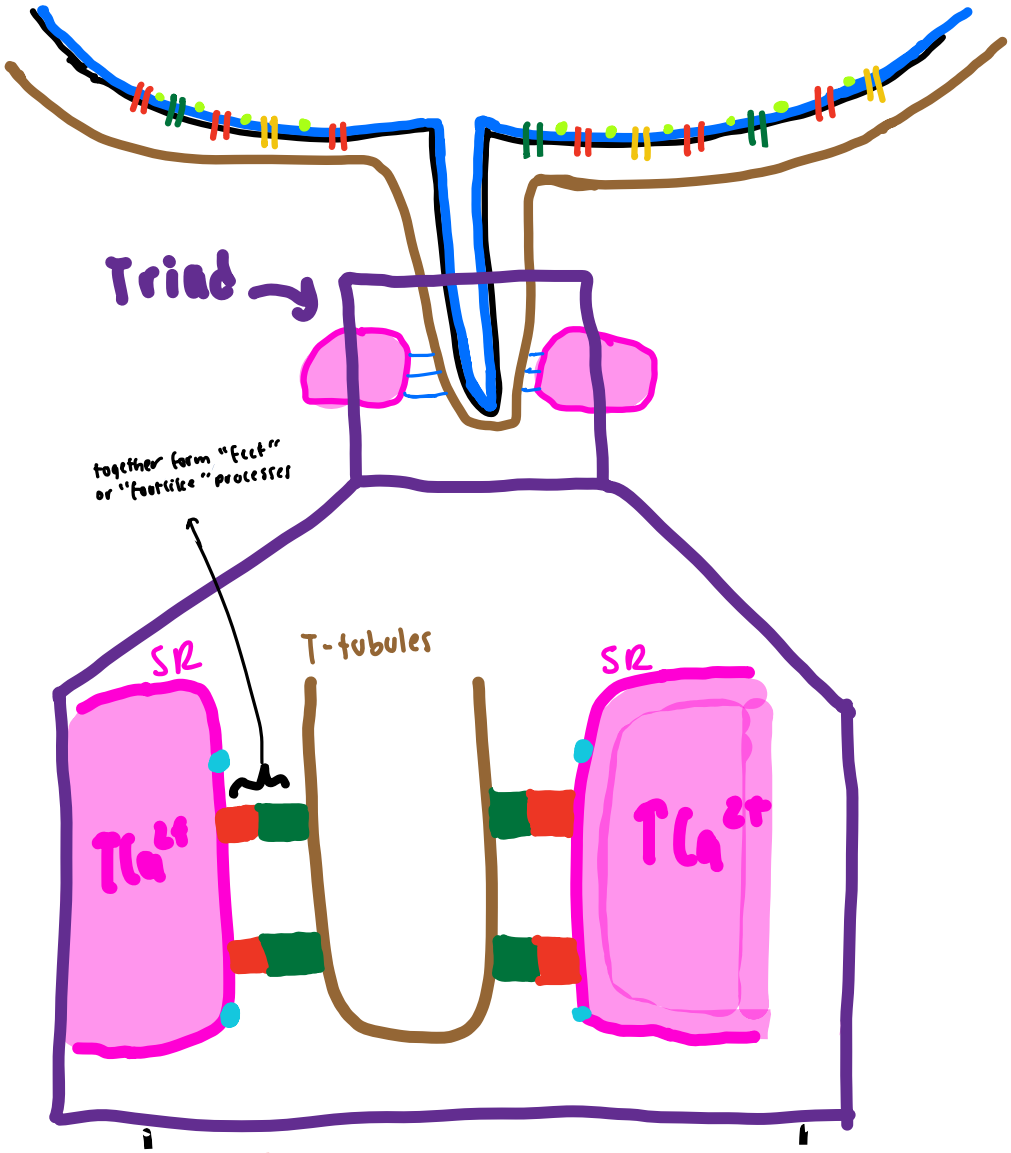
V6 Ca^{2+} channel:

- redistributed with V6 Na^+ channels
- causes Ca^{2+} entry into cell
  ↳ t-tubules allow for AP to reach inside the myofibril quickly



1 SMN, 1 NMJ per 1 muscle fiber

T-Tubule Depolarization + Ca^{2+} Release From SR



VG Ca^{2+} channel/ T-tubule protein/ dihydropyridine receptor/DHP-R

- opens upon T-tubule depolarization
- mechanically linked to RyR (when one opens, so does the other)
- located on T-tubule membrane

Ca^{2+} release channel/ SR membrane protein/ ryanodine receptor (RyR)

- opens as VG Ca^{2+} channels open
- Ca^{2+} from SR → muscle fiber cytoplasm via diffusion
- Ca^{2+} then interacts with thin filament for contraction
- located on SR membrane

Ca^{2+} pump protein/ SERCA

- functions as an ATPase
- pumps Ca^{2+} back into SR from cytoplasm (against gradient) by hydrolyzing ATP
- located on SR membrane

!this all occurs in 10ms!

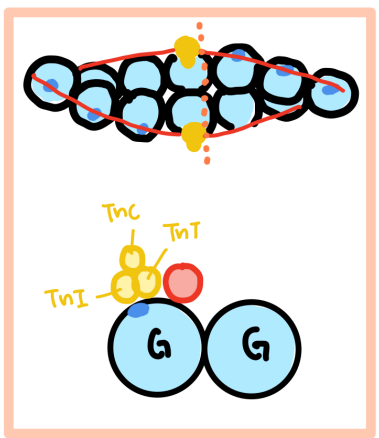
Ca^{2+} + Thin Filament = Contraction

• = g-actin
• = tropomyosin
• = troponin complex



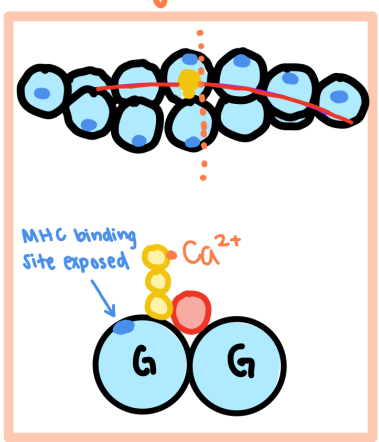
Low $[Ca^{2+}]$

Troponin Complex Proteins
- TnT → binds tropomyosin
- TnI → binds MHC binding site
- TnC → binds Ca^{2+}



- at rest, troponin + tropomyosin on top of MHC binding site

High $[Ca^{2+}]$



- once MHC binding site is exposed on G-actin → cross bridge formation + force production

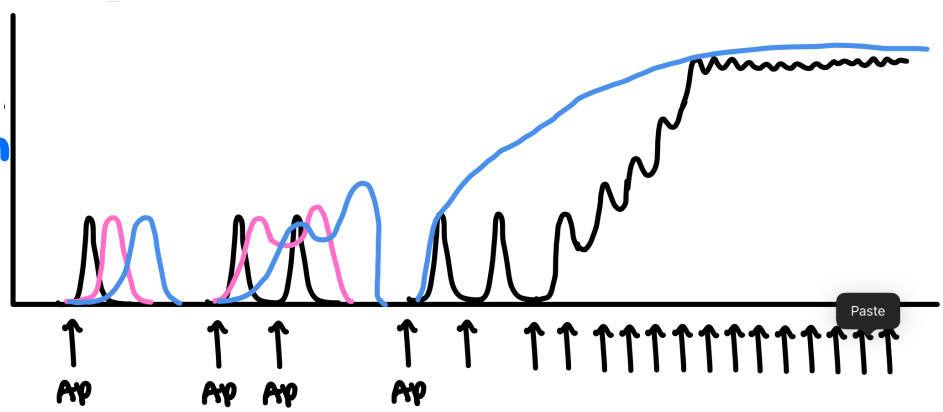
• all within 10 ms of Ach release from SMN

↑ to stop contraction:

- Stop Ach release via AchE
- AchR closes
- no opening of DHP or RyR
- SERCA returns $C[Ca^{2+}]$ back to rest

Levels of Muscle Stimulation:

—: depolarization
—: force production
—: $[Ca^{2+}]$



Single Muscle Twitch

- 1AP : 1 contraction = muscle twitch
- not enough Ca^{2+} to expose all myosin binding sites
  - not every TnC is removed
- Fast depolarization + repolarization
- Force occurs later/slower to return to rest

Summation

- stimulate 2x in quick succession
- ↑ in $C[Ca^{2+}]$ in cytosol ; still remaining in cytosol when receive another AP to release more Ca^{2+} from SR
- ↑ in force since not enough time between AP's for $C[Ca^{2+}]$ to return to rest

Tetanus

- very high frequency
- 3-5x ↑ in force production compared to 1 single twitch
- continuous firing of SMN = ↑↑ $C[Ca^{2+}]$ in cytosol = sustained force
  - ↑ SMN fires more as try harder + harder to lift something

Speed and Contractility Depends on MHC gene expression

- different enzymes: different kinetics
- — : slow MHC = Type 1 fibers (slow oxidative), fatigue-resistant
- — and ~ : fast MHC = Type 2 fibers

Type 2b:
- fast MHC
- glycolytic
- fatigueable

Type 2a:
- fast MHC
- oxidative/glycolytic
- "intermediate group"
- partially fatigue resistant

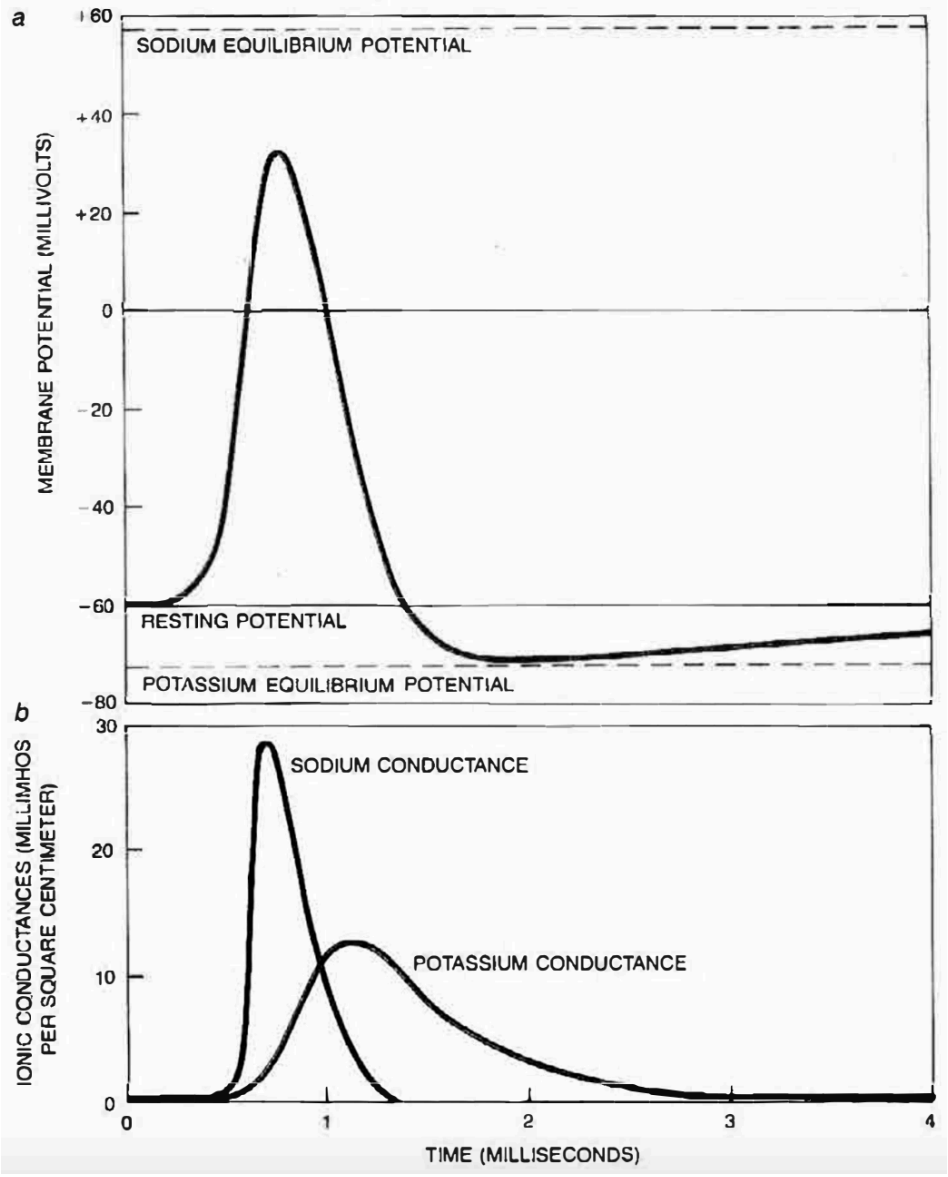
	Type 1	Type 2a	Type 2b
Vmax	slow	fast	fast
ox-phos	high	medium	low
glycolysis	low	medium	high
vasculature	high	medium	low
glycogen	low	medium	high
diameter	small	medium	large
[SERCA]	low	medium	high
RyR	low	medium	high
DHP	low	medium	high
SR	low	medium	high
mitochondria	high	medium	low
cytochrome	high	medium	low
[Mb]/[Fe^{2+}]	high	medium	low
color	red	pink	white

PhySci 111A
Winter ’26
Week 2 Worksheet

As the head TA for the Physci core series, one of my responsibilities includes creating worksheets for the learning assistants (LAs) to go over with the students in each discussion section. Prior to the discussion section, the LAs and I have a meeting where we go over the answers to the worksheet, explaining any concepts they need refreshment on and answering any questions. Then in discussion sections, the LAs are allotted approximately 25 minutes to go over the worksheet with the students. I not only create the questions for these worksheets obtaining approval from the professors, but I host the meeting with the LAs and ensure both LA understanding and student understanding

This is an example of one of the questions from the worksheet as well as the level of detail I include in my answer key and discuss with the LAs prior to them presenting it to the students.

Use the figure below to answer Questions 3-4. The figure is from a research article titled “Ion channels in the nerve-cell membrane.” by Richard D. Keynes (1979).



PhySci 111A
Winter '26
Week 2 Worksheet

1. Provide an explanation for the shape and temporal (timing) characteristics of the Na+ conductance trace.

LAs: First have the students analyze what the graph is showing: x-axis, y-axis, what each curve represents, before answering the questions.

- Influx of Na+ into the cell upon depolarization will rapidly open these voltage-gated Na+ channels. The Na+ conductance trace quickly rises to a high amplitude due to this quick opening.
    - The v-gated Na+ channel has 3 subunits that undergo change in configuration when the channel is activated by positive change in voltage (depolarization), so the channel will quickly open -> resulting in rapid influx of Na+ down its electrochemical gradient
- Na+ conductance soon decreases because the state of the channel changes from open to inactivated with time
- The decrease in Na+ conductance is closely followed by the increase in K+ conductance as K+ channels were slow to open from the initial change in voltage

Guiding / Check for Understanding Questions for LAs:

- How does the configuration/state of Na+ channels change and what causes them to change?
    - A: closed to open due to depolarization (change in voltage), open to inactivated due to time

2. Provide an explanation for the shape and temporal (timing) characteristics of the K+ conductance trace.

- The K+ conductance trace is much slower to rise and rises to a lower amplitude compared to Na+
- Once the Vm reaches ~+30 mV, the voltage-gated Na+ channels close, and the K+ channels open. These channels are slow to open and slow to close; hence the gradual increase and decrease in K+ conductance is due to K+ slowly leaking out of the cell down its electrochemical gradient
- Bear in mind that the K+ leak channels are allowing K+ ions to leak back into the cell simultaneously and there are a lot of K+ leak channels

Guiding / Check for Understanding Questions for LAs:

- What is the difference between voltage-gated K+ channels and voltage-gated Na+ channels?

Additional Q to ask: How would the action potential curve look if we were to overlay it on the conductance graph? (See Part A of the figure above) We can see that the upward curve of AP is consistent with the increase in Na+ conductance

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name: Poornima Dorairaj

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

I had Gabriella Sigal as my Teaching Assistant for the entirety of my junior year for the Physiological Sciences core classes, as well as now having her as the head TA while I am a learning assistant for these classes.

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

I am so lucky that I had Gabby as my TA throughout the Physiological Sciences core since there were many moments where I would doubt my ability or belonging in the major, and it was with Gabby's help and through attending her office hours that she reminded me I was meant to be there and helped me grow in my confidence in my abilities. PhySci 107 was understandably a challenging class with a dense course load, but Gabby spent extensive time giving us tips and tricks on memorizing content, while sharing about her experiences as a student and LA to remind us that we could succeed in this course. I remember one moment before the practical exam, where she saw how anxious I was and reminded me that I could only succeed if I let myself think and believed in what I knew, and that moment has stuck with me since. I know that for myself and other students, Gabby is the reason why we are still in the major, and she has given me both the preparation and confidence to succeed as an undergraduate outside of this class and major, which I am forever grateful for.

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

I have been lucky enough to be both a student of Gabriella's and also now serve as a learning assistant with her as the head TA. Over the past 1.5 years, I have seen how Gabby adapts the course material to match students' learning pace. She spent several hours developing discussion worksheets that were sometimes ten to fifteen pages in length, with comprehensive summaries of course material/content that forced many students to engage in the class through their intentional structure as fill-in-the-blank. Through this, Gabby motivated many of my peers and I to spend time reviewing and revising material as we learned it each week before our sections, so that we could effectively contribute and engage in our discussions. Outside of discussions, in her office hours, Gabby would often explain and re-explain concepts for students, ensuring that no matter how long it would take her, students would fully understand the material in detail before she moved on. It was moments like these that highlighted to me how much she really cared about our understanding and success in the courses, even if it meant taking extra time out of her busy schedule.

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

Gabby is one of the Teaching Assistants that you hope to have throughout your undergraduate experience, but only a few students really ever get. I believe that it was Gabby's hard work and commitment not just to the Physiological Sciences major but also to her students, including me, that really made me feel like I had a place in this major, despite the challenges and personal obstacles I encountered that year. I know for a fact that I am only one of many students who shared this experience, and I believe that she is truly deserving of this award.

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Lilit Ohanian

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

I am a teaching assistant in the Integrative Biology and Physiology Department, and I have been working alongside Gabby for 4 quarters. Together, we work as teaching assistants for the Physiological Science Core series.

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Gabby has inspired my teaching in a variety of ways. When we first began teaching in the Physiological Science Core series, I struggled most with leading human cadaver anatomy labs. Communicating anatomical orientation clearly and confidently felt overwhelming, and I often doubted whether I was explaining concepts effectively. When I shared these concerns with her, she immediately helped quiet my imposter syndrome with thoughtful encouragement and practical advice. More than offering reassurance, she took the time to help me refine how I verbally communicated spatial relationships and anatomical landmarks to students. Her mentorship extended far beyond that moment. Gabby is incredibly intentional about supporting teaching assistants as they craft their teaching materials, structure their sections, and develop their own instructional style. She encourages us to move beyond simply delivering information and instead foster open-ended discussion, critical thinking, and genuine curiosity in the classroom. Through her guidance, I became a more confident and student-centered instructor. Her commitment to mentorship and collaboration has strengthened our entire teaching team and profoundly shaped my growth as an educator.

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Gabby consistently goes above and beyond for her own students. One way in which Gabby has taken additional steps in order to benefit her students' learning was when she integrated her students' comments into her own teaching. Throughout the start of the quarter, many students felt that they were having difficulty engaging with complex lecture material, and felt that discussion sections weren't the most conducive to their learning. Taking this feedback into consideration, she sought to shift discussion sections from a lecture format to open-ended discussions. She made weekly, hand-drawn discussion worksheets that included questions that prompted students to think about the material beyond course content. These changes allowed her students to actively engage with the course material and greatly encouraged them to collaborate with one another both during sections and during independent study time.

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

An additional reason that Gabby is an outstanding candidate for this award is her role as the head teaching assistant in the Physiological Science Core course. In this role, she has taken on additional responsibilities from previous quarters. Aside from administrative responsibilities and ensuring communication between professors and teaching assistants, such responsibilities have included helping guide first year teaching assistants in leading discussion sections and grading as well as mentoring undergraduate learning assistants to present course material in discussion sections, successfully facilitate open-ended discussions, and encourage collaboration amongst students.

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)